

10.1 The Backup And Restore Center

The basic file backup and restore features in Windows Vista make it easy for you to keep your data and your computer safe from user error, hardware failure, and other problems. In the Home Premium, Business, Ultimate, and Enterprise editions of Windows Vista, you can automate the entire backup process using a simple Wizard which will even schedule your future backups for you.

An important thing to consider here is that the Wizard does not allow you to back up specific folders and files, that is, you cannot select the data you want to back up. Rather, the backup program scans your hard drive for data that matches certain criteria, and backs it up. The criteria can be defined and modified through the Wizard, however. IT professionals might balk at this new system, now that they cannot determine precisely what needs to be backed up. For home users, it makes things easier—it is a very easy task to start backing up your data; there's no need to worry about just what ought to be saved.

As to what gets backed up: all your personal files and folders—no system files are backed up by the program. Programs and system files are not included in the file backup, but they can be separately restored by reinstallation or by using either system restore points or Complete PC Backup and Restore—a feature available in the Business, Ultimate, and Enterprise editions of Vista.

The Backup and Restore Center also offers periodic backup for your data. Through a simple Wizard you can schedule your backups; note that future backups are incremental in nature. Which means that when the program is first run, it will back up all your personal files, but on future runs, it will only archive changes made to your files—thus if you added a slide to a presentation, after your first backup, the program will only add that particular slide to your original backup. Incremental backups thus make future backups much faster.